

RAJ CHENGAPPA



IF THE GREENLAND ICE SHEET MELTS, SEA LEVELS COULD RISE BY SEVEN METRE SUBMERGING ISLAND COUNTRIES AND SWAMPING COASTAL CITIES LIKE MUMBAI.

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ICE STATION NEEM: The team of scientists at the camp site (above) and their car with special wheels for ice traction

rying thinning of the ice cap at its periphery. The Arctic Ice around the North Pole too is melting rapidly and last year for the first time ships were able to navigate through what was once frozen seas. "If this goes on unchecked, there would be no snow in Santa's land and no presents for our children," says Minik Thorleif Rosing, professor at the National History Museum of Denmark, half seriously.

Rosing is a tall, pony-tailed Inuit whose population totals just 50,000 in the world's largest island that is not a con-

tinental and is two-thirds the size of India. His ancestors once hunted all across the North Pole but the Inuit now find themselves at the frontline of global warming. And as Rosing points out, nothing in their past experience has prepared them for the oncoming crisis. So they cannot rely on traditional knowledge to guide them.

Kim Kielsen, another Inuit, concurs. He is the young and handsome minister of housing, infrastructure, minerals and petroleum in the Greenland Government (Greenland is an autonomous province of the Kingdom of Denmark). He greets you with a humorous, "Welcome to the coolest place on earth."

Then he turns serious. Holding his palm in level with his nose, he says, "This is the level of water in my favourite hunting places as a result of melting ice. In the past these always remained frozen in sum-

mer." He adds: "I hope the world can act quickly to halt global warming because our children will not be able to see the Polar bear walk on ice as my generation had seen."

So the mission of the tiny research station in the northern extreme of the ice cap over Greenland becomes critical. Called the North Greenland Eemian Ice Drilling (NEEM) project, it began last year and is the fifth such ice coring research project in the region. The earlier probes yielded significant findings of the rapid changes that the earth's climate experienced. They include a study that showed that in the past, temperatures could warm up to 10 to 12 degrees in a span of just 25 years during some periods. Also that the trigger for the onset of the last Ice Age was dramatic disturbances from the tropics including dust storms and not oceanic currents or ice formation as thought of before. "What was missing though from these